

ONE

Understanding Regional Knowledge Systems

This introduction is designed to equip you with a clear understanding of the core concepts and terminology that you will come across in this book. The purpose is for you to have a firm grasp on our specific definition of 'knowledge' and the dual understanding of 'region' – both as a physical space and as a cultural entity. Furthermore, the meaning and implications of various other crucial terms and categories used throughout the text will also be clarified – what is meant by 'system' when discussing knowledge systems, and how we use categories like 'ethnic groups', 'castes' and 'communities'.

Definition of Kerala as a Region

A region is generally defined as a landscape that is intelligible geographically, historically, linguistically and politically. All regions need not necessarily share cultural practices such as religion, rituals, rites, customs and traditions. Even language could be functionally different due to mutually exclusive dialects. Still, there would be a predominant language that binds most dialects. Since Malayalam is the predominant language of Kerala, the region central to our textbook, it binds together most dialects, even the languages of people of the forest. Hence, we can say that Kerala is a politically constituted linguistic state. It is in the sense of a politically defined and delimited space of linguistic identity that we consider Kerala as a region.

Geographically, Kerala shows certain physical characteristics of forested hills, plains, backwaters and the littoral. Historically and linguistically this particular geographical space was called 'Malayalam' (landscape between *mala* meaning hill and *alam* meaning the sea, i.e., the land between the hills and the sea) and 'Cheralam' (*cher* means merge and *alam* means the sea, i.e., the land merging with the sea). It is from *Cheralam* that the name Keralam is derived. Popularly, Kerala is mistakenly linked to the Sanskrit word *nalikera* meaning coconut. Interestingly, coconut has become a widespread crop in the region only in the last seven hundred years. But the name Kerala has been found way back in the Ashokan Edict of the third century BCE. Similarly, the Dravidian word for coconut is *tenkai*

(fruit from the south) from which the Malayalam word *thenga* is derived. All other etymological interpretations of the region's name are linguistically unfounded.

Kerala is not simply a geographically bound and isolated place. It has always had links with cultures of other parts of the world. There is no 'knowledge' that can be claimed by any region as entirely its own. Conversations and interactions between the material and conceptual fields of different places have always been taking place in a non-hierarchical manner. Most elements of knowledge applied in one region are borrowed either as such or piecemeal from other places and sources. The exact provenance or the place of origins of a given knowledge system is never identifiable. In that sense, every form of knowledge is of a composite nature.

The people of Kerala have adapted to its physiographically diverse landscape ecosystems since times immemorial. Their existence over the years involved production and modification of technology and knowledge for subsistence and survival in these different landscapes. Naturally, their living conditions, ideas, institutions, and organisational structures were uneven and diverse in terms of development. For this reason, we will adopt different categories such as 'ethnic groups', 'communities' and 'castes' in the textbook.

How Do We Define Categories?

Ethnic groups are defined as people who share a common historical tradition, language, culture, physical features and identity. This definition is an anthropological attribution which would eventually undergo changes through education, acculturation and assimilation. We apply this definition now in our discussion of knowledge inherited as oral tradition across generations; specifically, in the case of people living in landscape ecosystems like forests and forest fringes. The anthropological term 'tribe' has not been used due to the largely flexible and partially acculturated condition of these people. A tribe is more exclusive and localised as compared to ethnic groups which are inclusive as well as widespread.

In anthropology, **community** refers to local people with shared cultural identity and a sense of belonging, with common customs, practices and values. They adapt to new material conditions of existence and change accordingly, but continue to believe that the changed life is still the tradition. In a generic sense, a community means a group of people with shared norms, practices, values and passions with some shared identity due to the same locality, residential area, profession, institution and so on. In this textbook, based on the context, we have used community as an anthropological term as well as in the generic sense.

The term **caste** has been used to refer to endogamous groups of people identified originally as *jatis*, linked to hereditary occupation groups.

What is Knowledge?

As we have already discussed, development has largely been variable among people living in different ecosystem landscapes; this has accounted for the variety in the types or forms of their knowledge and technology. It is important, therefore, to define knowledge in a way that considers people's strategies of subsistence and survival in an inclusive way.

In the case of people surviving in different landscape ecosystems, knowledge refers to the skills, understanding, and traditional wisdom which each generation inherits and passes on to the next generation. It is this traditionally acquired practical knowledge that enables the people to meet everyday challenges and survive in the given environment. Naturally, knowledge in this context is intimately associated with the locally specific landscape ecosystem.

Knowledge was often conveyed through the shaman's perceived connection to supernatural powers. People revered Nature in the form of local deities and practised various magical rites and rituals linked to it. However, at its core, this involved the need for a sustainable use of natural resources. The knowledge held by the forest people, for instance, included insights into how animals and plants are interconnected within their ecosystem. Likewise, the knowledge of communities dependent on sea resources revealed the dependent existence of sea-life. Hence, their traditional practices were based on the values of conservation.

What is Knowledge System?

In the chapters of this textbook, we discuss the Knowledge Systems of Kerala (KSK), which is also the title of your course. As you may be aware, at the national level there is a compulsory course titled Indian Knowledge System (IKS). This course is a related one that contains all globally noted knowledge contributions of the country. In the present course, there is no assumption of a hierarchical relationship between region, nation and the world.

A system is made up of its constituents which are interconnected entities. By 'knowledge system' we mean a system constituted of interrelated components of knowledge. In the context of this textbook, the constituents of knowledge are not the usual components that we understand today.

us see that knowledge is not merely a neutral body of facts but is shaped by the prevailing social relations, reinforcing and being reinforced by them.

A knowledge system does not exist in a vacuum but is deeply influenced by the economic, political and social realities of the time. For example, medieval European knowledge systems were shaped by religious and feudal structures, while modern scientific systems are influenced by capitalist and industrial dynamics.

It is crucial to understand how science became the dominant form of knowledge and what factors made the Western model of knowledge 'scientific'. To understand knowledge systems in different parts of the world, we should know the difference between the Western and Indian models of knowledge.

In most cases, the systems of knowledge at the regional and national levels are the same but for the differences in the language. However, just as European languages had dominance over Sanskrit, Sanskrit had dominance over regional languages in shaping how knowledge was structured.

Our textbook adopts a more inclusive and nuanced understanding of the history of knowledge by focusing on multiple knowledge systems throughout history. This implies that the history of knowledge is a complex, multi-dimensional process that involves the interplay of power, culture, politics and social structures, rather than a linear development of knowledge through accumulation of facts and ideas over time.

Historical knowledge discussed in the textbook is divided into two categories: one that is embedded in the material objects and the other explicit in written texts. The knowledge embedded in material objects include things such as archaeological relics as well as historical objects of material culture such as tools, implements, rock-art and artefacts. Chapters Two and Three provide various examples of these and explain them in detail.

Chapters Four and Five deal with the knowledge that was written down. The methods we use to learn about these things and the knowledge we gain from studying them are part of academic knowledge, and this kind of knowledge improves over time through research.

Academic Knowledge

What is academic knowledge? How is it different from traditional knowledge? Academic knowledge is specialised knowledge – systematic, explicit, codified

and ever-improving. It is not the empirically given primary knowledge, but a subsequently constituted knowledge abstracted out of logical generalisations based on evidence. Academic knowledge is widely shared within academia, because of its currently accepted validity.

Academic knowledge is different from the common knowledge that everyone uses in a community, even though its usage varies from individual to individual. Some people are naturally practical and use knowledge more intelligently depending on the context. Others may just follow what everyone does without much thought. Nevertheless, everyone tends to take this knowledge as inherited wisdom and accepts it without questioning. In this context, scholars sometimes use 'knowledge' and 'wisdom' as words conveying the same meaning.

People with sharp common sense who can think critically and realistically look at academic knowledge differently; they want proof and do not accept wisdom as self-evident. They seek evidence of truth behind wisdom, before accepting it. According to them, wisdom refers to the highest state of insightful application of truthful knowledge. So, they see wisdom as a more improved and advanced form of academic knowledge. Interestingly, scholars of academic wisdom recognise that the common wisdom of a community is superior when it comes to matters of ecological sustainability, resilience, justice and ethics.

Have you thought of the process involved in the improvement of academic knowledge? It is achieved through a process called research. Knowledge that is accepted for a while can change; however, it does not change without reason. Researchers change it in the light of new evidence or when they have a more logical explanation. Karl Popper, a famous Austrian-British philosopher, said that research is not just about repeating what is already known but about trying to refute it through the discovery of fresh evidence or more refined logic. This is the process of knowing knowledge closely – by becoming critically conscious about it and creatively engaging with it. This is how academic knowledge is created and sometimes replaced.

Research Is Inevitable

This historical approach to knowledge systems or knowledge cultures seldom intends to explain things with proof or discloses their underlying principles. However, this does not mean research is not important or inevitable. Instead, it considers the anthropological context of a historically given knowledge form with

its own set of dependent attributes. This includes their community, vocabulary, relations and what purpose that knowledge served for them. All this makes sense within their own unique culture. This demands academic knowledge based on research in anthropology.

It is not part of the anthropological approach to research to decide what criteria should be followed for identifying knowledge. We do not want to force our modern definitions of knowledge onto the past. Of course, sometimes we do see things in past knowledge that are similar to or even connected to how we understand present-day knowledge. They are often instances of scholarly production of codified knowledge by specialists, consciously engaged out of passion and personal curiosity. In such cases we see knowledge as codified texts authored by specialist individuals.

In the case of tacit, embedded, and symbolic knowledge, a significant difference is the absence of individual authors. This knowledge has only individual users. It is knowledge produced by the collective and inherited by individuals as its practitioners. Although individual users add to the traditional knowledge, the additions always merge with the tradition and become too indistinguishable to be identified with any specific authors.

But then the question arises, who decided what counted as a knowledge system in the past in the case of the non-explicit or tacit, embedded and symbolic knowledge? We can understand this by looking at what we know about the subsistence and survival strategies of people in history. We locate knowledge and knowledge systems in history by understanding the anthropological basis of abstract concepts like beliefs and concrete practices like material productions in history.

Knowledge systems are interdisciplinary, bringing together insights from various fields such as philosophy, economics, politics and science, each of them operating within its own specific historical context. The term 'systems' allows us to acknowledge the interconnectedness of different domains of knowledge, even as they arise in distinct social and historical contexts. This cross-pollination of ideas between different knowledge systems shows how diverse societies develop methods to understand, control, or navigate their environments.

The term 'systems' also captures the idea that knowledge is adaptable and flexible. In different social formations, knowledge systems may be reshaped or restructured in response to changing material conditions or shifts in the social order. For example, scientific knowledge in the pre-industrial era had different systems of thought than the modern scientific systems of today.

caste groups (see discussion above). When *Keralolppatti* says that Parasurama arranged slaves for the Brahmins, it implies the enslavement of the farmer clans by the Brahmins.

Keralolppatti was used as the 'master chronicle' by all regional rulers for their historical legitimacy and power. Every change in the narrative was linked to the central legend of Parasurama. Similarly, various local cultural practices have been absorbed into the chronicle. Some of the cult centres, shrines, rituals and rites were linked to the chronicle for tracing their origins. Certain counter-traditions of protest and dissent against Brahmin domination are articulated in the *Thottam-pāṭṭu* of the *Theyyam* cult of north Malabar.

Folklore

'Folklore' refers to traditional knowledge and beliefs which have usually been passed down through generations by word of mouth. It comprises cultural ideas, concepts, artefacts and institutions, preserved and transferred across generations. There are many types of folklore: folksongs, folktales, folk dances and magico-ritual performances. Generally, folktales are narrated in verse (*pāṭṭukatha*), like those largely grouped as part of fertility cults. There are songs like *Payyannūr Pāṭṭu*, which are comprehensive narratives of local history. If listened to carefully and studied for their salient features, folksongs unravel the knowledge stratum underlying their musical rhythms and apparent story narratives. Indeed, the musical rhythms and story narratives also convey contemporary knowledge about them, but below the surface of the text. They signify the complex concepts of the local people's music.

The knowledge that we derive from folklore/oral narratives should not be reduced to individual belief; rather, it is social knowledge. Furthermore, since they are produced and generated from the social world specific to a locality, they are embedded in situational contexts. However, their embedded nature (and that they are linked to specific cultural worlds) does not exclude them from being considered knowledge. Any discussion on folklore/oral narratives related to rituals, which are specific to Kerala, as traditional knowledge, demands acceptance of this assumption. Let's discuss a specific example.

The oral narratives that tell the myths about the origin of *Theyyam*, a ritual worship of ancestors and local divinities specific to north Kerala, are called *Thottam*. Each *Theyyam* has a specific *Thottam* dedicated to it. Additionally, there are several parts to a *Thottam*, including invocation, songs of praise, description of the myth and singing for prosperity. Though there are views that these might have been

composed by an individual, we must admit that they are products of a collective, perhaps transcending time and space. *Thottams* are sung during the manifestation of a *Theyyam*. On an apparent level, one may perceive *Thottam* as a simple linear narrative of the myth of the origin of a deity being worshipped. However, it has layers of meaning, producing and disseminating knowledge about the social world. The knowledge produced ranges from the birth of the cosmic world, strategies to be followed while hunting, meticulous details of the methods of wetland paddy cultivation, social and kinship relations of the society, and discussions on social values like egalitarianism and individualism. It also discusses the importance of affinity in the matrilineal Malabar kinship system that value consanguinity. In the following section, we discuss three instances of how *Thottams* present knowledge on the social world of Malabar.

Among the many *Theyyams* performed in Malabar households, *Pottan Theyyam* holds a prominent place. It is worshipped as a gesture of thanksgiving for favours received, or as a periodic ritual for the well-being of a family. The central theme of the popular myth involves an intellectual discussion between *Pottan*, symbolising ignorance or simplicity, and Shankaracharya, the epitome of knowledge. The myth further depicts Pottan as devoid of any knowledge, portraying him as a Pulaya slave. This dialectical representation sets the stage for the ensuing exchange.



Pottan Theyyam performance

Acknowledged as the paragon of wisdom, Shankaracharya embarks on a journey to occupy the seat of supreme knowledge. While passing through a narrow ridge in the middle of a paddy field, he encounters a Pulaya man and his family. According to custom, when a Brahmin approaches, a Pulaya should move aside to avoid causing pollution by sight. Shankaracharya asked the Pulaya to move away, but the latter refused, questioning where they should move. In a poignant exchange, he poses several probing questions to Shankaracharya, leaving the latter momentarily speechless. His inquiries encompass two distinct themes: one challenges the logic behind hierarchical classification of individuals, rendering some as 'unapproachable'; the other dismantles the artificial boundary between theory and practice.

Pottan eloquently argues that the colour of blood, identical in both a labouring Pulaya and an intellectual Brahmin, renders hierarchical distinctions meaningless. Moreover, he questions why we should differentiate between theory and practice when the labour of individuals serves as a conduit for knowledge acquisition. This assertion underscores the futility of stratifying information and complex knowledge, ultimately advocating for egalitarian principles. At its core, Pottan's discourse champions the value of egalitarianism, asserting that any society failing to uphold equality warrants scrutiny, regardless of endorsements from authoritative sources. He posits that knowledge devoid of inclusivity necessitates revision and adaptation.

The whole discussion would become more meaningful if we consider the possible historical context in which such an intellectual exchange would have taken place in Kerala. The two agents who were involved in the discourse are Shankaracharya, a Brahmin who produced knowledge to legitimise the hierarchical social order of medieval Kerala that would cater to Brahmanical interests, and the Pulaya, who were then largely inducted as slave labourers (*adiyalar*) in the newly expanding wetland paddy agriculture. In the *Thottam-pāṭṭu* of *Pottan Theyyam*, this historical context has been symbolically appropriated to produce the knowledge of the marginalised about social order and the values on which a society should be built. They bring to the fore the concepts of hierarchy and egalitarianism.

It is known that the classification of societies, in the modern sense, began in the nineteenth century with Western scholarship. European society was often portrayed as egalitarian, while Oriental societies were labelled as hierarchical. This classification was often perceived as an inherent and timeless characteristics of the East. However, an examination of the *Thottam* of *Pottan Theyyam* not only offers explicit knowledge about the ideals of society but also serves as a potential source for questioning Orientalist constructions in the present.

Folklore and oral narratives play a crucial role in shaping the knowledge aimed at constructing new social paradigms. An illustrative instance of this phenomenon is the recognition of individualism, which entails the capacity to resist succumbing to collective pressures. The folklore under consideration here revolves around the *Thottam* recited to embody a *Theyyam* known as Kathivanoor Veeran. Analysing the structure of the *Thottam* and the myths surrounding the origin of Kathivanoor Veeran suggests a probable dating to the eighteenth century or later.



Kathivanoor Veeran Theyyam performance

The narrative of Kathivanoor Veeran can be summarised as follows: originally named Mannappan, he was born to Thiyya parents. Despite societal expectations and familial pressure, Mannappan refused to adhere to his caste's traditional occupation, leading to his expulsion from both his family and village. He relocated to Coorg and engaged in oil trade, a profession deemed unconventional in the eighteenth-century social hierarchy. Through determination and resilience, Mannappan achieved success and attained economic independence, enabling him to marry a partner from a lower caste, defying prevailing social norms and asserting his individual autonomy. However, his life ends tragically in battle, though not before displaying valour in combat. Subsequently, he is deified and worshipped as *Kathivanoor Veeran Theyyam*.

The eighteenth century in Malabar marks a transitional period from medieval societal structures, which emphasised collective determinism even while recognising individual existence, to a more modern framework that acknowledges the rational choices of individuals as the basis for action. It is within this liminal phase of transition that the *Theyyam* Kathivanoor Veeran gains significance and relevance. His ritual worship portrays him as a courageous individual who bestows blessings upon those in need, often in contexts shaped by modern institutions. Examples include seeking his intervention for favourable court rulings or the safe return of migrant workers from abroad, such as from the Middle East. The establishment of permanent shrines dedicated to worshipping him is a relatively recent development.

The *Thottam* narrates Mannappan's life experience as an exceptional case, serving as a means to generate knowledge about a society in the making or the society that eighteenth-century Malabar aspired to create. Despite Malabar's historical connectivity to the wider world, the adoption of Western notions like individualism, which emerged in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, was rare. However, local inhabitants, driven by aspirations and seizing opportunities amidst changing social and economic conditions, sought to envision a new social order. Folklore played a crucial role in imbuing meaning to the knowledge essential for such imaginings. Thus, the narrative of individualism within folklore emerges as a product of the social dynamics within Malabar, rather than an idea imported from distant sources.

There are occasions when folklore/oral narratives becomes historical form of knowledge. To understand this, one needs to depart from the modern Western enlightenment concept of historical knowledge as an objective truth produced on empirical evidence, connected by causal relation, and presented in a linear narrative. Various successful attempts have been made to challenge the aforementioned concept of historical knowledge, including the assertion that, history as a form of knowledge was unknown to us till colonial rule. Historians are now recognising the longstanding existence of an indigenous historical consciousness, often established through oral traditions such as songs. The following section discusses how folklore/oral narratives, along with its ritual enactment, transforms into historical forms of knowledge. Such a history could be called 'mnemonic history', where the memory of collective experiences is narrativised as well as set as ritual to be remembered in future.

The question of how such a subjective experience and culturally specific knowledge can be accepted as valid, needs to be answered. To be valued as knowledge, the

scale of acceptance should not be a criterion; it could be universal or particular to a small village, or to a region. That is, the foundation of such a transition lies in redefining knowledge not merely as true, justified belief, but as situational – namely, ‘knowledge held at a particular time’. Therefore, knowledge is not solely factual but also emerges from the context in which it originates. Secondly, since it is culturally specific, they wrote history in the mode that is dominant in its own literary practice. A fundamental question might arise here: if knowledge was situational and presented in a non-universal mode, then who within society held those beliefs as knowledge? An answer to who holds it as knowledge must go beyond identifying an individual or a collective but as a creative spatial relation that challenges hegemonic discourses and unsettles existing structures of domination. With this understanding, in the succeeding paragraphs, we will discuss a corpus of *Thottam* as mnemonic history, a historical form of knowledge held by marginalised groups.

The mythical representation of the creation of Kerala says that it is a land reclaimed from the sea by Parasurama and then donated to Brahmins who established villages there. Since it is created by Parasurama and then donated to Brahmins, the myth dismisses the chance of any prior existence of inhabitants or resistance by such inhabitants. This is a form of historical knowledge that is circulated. Meanwhile, *Thottam* offers a completely different historical knowledge of the event. The existence of people prior to the coming of the Brahmins and their resistance against the Brahmins are narrated through *Thottam* songs, and transformed through generations as memory. For them, memory stands as a form of historical knowledge.

A corpus of *Thottam*, collected from Payyanur in Kannur district, one of the early Brahmin settlements in medieval Kerala, narrativises and performs the experiences of their ancestors. The *Thottams* say that the Payyanur Subrahmanya Swami Temple was built by the labour of the Pulayas brought from a nearby village. Once the temple was constructed, the Pulayas were not only excluded from the temple but were also killed.

In the first part of the *Thottam*, it narrates the forced relocation of a group of people from the nearby village to build the temple. The contract stated that they should complete the construction in the span of a night, else they would not receive wages. Although they completed the work, the labourers were not given their wages.

In the second *Thottam*, a Pulaya girl, named Arayil Chirutha, enters the newly constructed Brahmanic temple along with six upper-caste women but is forcefully

pushed out from the temple, and is accused of polluting it. Though the *Thottam* mentions that she was granted a small piece of land in the middle of a paddy field by a Brahmin landlord, who was also a temple trustee, and was looked after by an upper-caste woman, the *Thottam* also says that she was worshipped as Arayil Bhagavathi, a woman killed and deified. A *Theyyam* for Arayil Bhagavathi is still performed in a shrine near the temple, narrating her experiences in the form of *Thottam*.

The third *Thottam* tells of the marriage of the expelled Pulaya girl and her giving birth to a baby boy named Virunthan. When he grew up, he was first asked to work in the paddy field of the landlord and later on the borders of the village as a guard. When the army of the White people attacked the temple, everyone was frightened and they abandoned the temple. However, Virunthan decided to fight back. By chanting hymns, he dampened the gunpowder of the White army and thwarted the attack. However, the elites who were supposed to defend the temple became afraid of Virunthan's abilities and wanted to eliminate him, which they executed successfully with the consent of the Brahmin landlord and the temple trustee. However, the Brahmin family was cursed for this deceit and they were afflicted with madness. To get rid of this curse, they were asked to deify Virunthan as a *Theyyam* and perform rites for him by giving a piece of land for that purpose. This was accepted, and thus began the manifestation of Virunthan as a *Theyyam*.

As already discussed, all these events are sung as *Thottam* while Virunthan is worshipped as *Theyyam*, and the major events in his life are enacted while his ritual manifestation occurs. He is worshipped as *Theyyam* exclusively by a lineage of the Pulaya of Payyanur. It is a ritual lasting a whole night. Everyone gathers at the sacred space dedicated for his worship and begins singing the *Thottam*. Before that, they will select a ritual specialist among the family members of Virunthan to manifest him as *Theyyam*. What is narrated and visualised is the corporeal experiences of the Pulaya labourers as a whole and that of Arayil Chirutha and Virunthan. They communicate history through the singing and ritual performances, a mode that is completely under their control. What is narrated as memory and enacted as ritual are their experiences. Therefore, the singing and the ritual enactment together constitute what is called mnemonic history.

It is sung not as an individual experience but as the collective experience of those who were suppressed, thus becoming a conduit for contemporary imagination of caste identity. Here, the ritual stands as a mnemonic commitment, meant to remember corporeal experiences in the future. This is how they construct their history and transfer it to the next generation. Here, memory stands both as a

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fact and images of the past as well as structures of consciousness. Together, they visualise what happened in the past and how what happened was experienced.

Memory was a form of history before the advent of modern enlightenment rationality. The latter pushed memory aside as subjective and imaginative, thus excluding it from the realm of knowledge. The history shaped by Western Enlightenment rationality devalues subjective experience and asserts official archival documentary evidence as fact. Inherent in this understanding of history is the potential to dominate societies that were illiterate. As Velcheru Narayana Rao, David Shulman and Sanjay Subrahmanyam say, each group writes history in the mode that is dominant in its own literary practice. By the same token, newly ascendant or powerful cultures might deny history to the communities they sought to dominate, and historicity to their texts. What constitutes history is not a given, in some universal sense, but practices specific to time and place. Such practices might war with one another; in the process, the history of the vanquished might itself be lost. The cases analysed here illustrate the possibilities of reclaiming history as a form of knowledge different from that of Enlightenment rationality. From this perspective, the *Thottam* and the rituals are a way of writing history by the marginalised, appropriating the mode of writing they are familiar with.

Heroic Ballads

Ballads are heroic songs composed and sung by bards (panegyric singers) in praise of the exploits, might and mien of prominent fighters. Northern ballads (*Vatakkān Pāṭṭukal*), composed and sung by the bardic caste called the Panas, narrate the adventurous stories of fighter-heroes to spread their fame and to please them. There are many such ballads, but only twenty-four of them, perhaps the most popular, are available in published collections. There were many songs widely sung by women as they engaged in planting paddy seedlings.

There are many families of fighter-heroes celebrated in the ballads. However, foremost among them are two – the Puthuram Thiyya family, and the Thacholi Manikkoth Nair family – famed for the heritage of victorious heroes. Aromal Chekavar of the Puthuram family and Thacholi Othenan of the Thacholi family are the most glorified fighters in the ballads. Unniyarcha of the Puthuram family ranks foremost among the women fighters. All the stories in the ballads centre around armed duels (*ankam*) of heroes with their enemies. This enmity was normally based on the familial obligation of retaliation or counter-retaliation (*kutipaka*) against the fighter who had killed the hero's maternal uncle in a duel. A woman's

denial of the fighter's invitation to be his partner and the consequent kidnapping could be another cause for a duel. It could also be caused by an incidental dispute between two fighters who are rivals in the field.

In fact, these celebrated heroes were mercenaries obliged to fight as hired fighters for settling disputes between members of the ruling families or landlords or such elites. Such fights on behalf of others and killings gave rise to retaliation and counter-retaliation. In the absence of a state power and a proper juridical system, the mercenaries' *ankam* had become a legitimate means of deciding one's righteousness. *Ankams* were also an important source of revenue for the king. This made the tradition of *Kalaripayattu* and *Kalari*-based martial training gain political importance too.

In terms of knowledge systems, what we ferret out from the ballads relates to their underlying techniques of versification, composition and structure. M. R. Raghava Varier, the renowned Indian epigraphist and historian, has studied such underlying composition techniques of northern ballads. Based on the insights drawn from the model developed by Vladimir Propp through his analysis of Russian fairy tales, Varier has demonstrated the techniques of composition in these ballads. They use stock expressions to poetically narrate the personal attributes of the hero, his attire, the route to the site of the fight, the nature of the fight, etc.

Varier has shown that every ballad has more or less the same structure, function and sequence, as construed by Propp in his study, but not without the various deviations through the legendary episode. We can summarise this structure: A hero leaves home. An interdiction is addressed to the hero: 'don't go there.' The interdiction is violated (and a villain appears in the story). The villain causes harm/injury to the hero's family. The family lacks something or desires something. The hero leaves home. The hero is tested, interrogated, attacked, etc. The hero and the villain engage in direct combat. The villain is defeated and killed. The initial misfortune or lack is resolved (object of search distributed, spell broken, slain person revived, captive freed). The hero returns. The hero is pursued (the pursuer tries to kill, eat, or undermine the hero). The hero is rescued from the pursuit (obstacles delay pursuer, hero hides or is hidden). The hero transforms so that he is unrecognisable. The villain presents unfounded claims. A difficult task proposed to the hero (trial by ordeal, riddles, test of strength/endurance, other tasks). The task is resolved. The villain is exposed. The hero is given a new recognition. The hero marries and ascends the throne.

What we derive as knowledge is that the *Vadakkan Pāṭṭukal* were composed by the bardic people who had formed the Pana caste that had inherited the oral techniques of versification along with stock words, phrases, metaphors and stylistic expressions. Most of the contexts were stereotypical and each of them already had versified sets, which every Pana knew. He could understand what to use out of the available sets, while he versified an apparently new story. He could easily do this selection and sing instantaneously. Furthermore,

Vadakkan Pāṭṭukal follow the universal sequence of oral ballads. The sequence can be summarised as follows: a lack, setting out of the hero, an interdiction on the way, its overcoming, the ploy of the enemy, the hero's strategic escape, his direct encounter with the enemy, and the hero's victorious return after remedying the lack. If any narrative follows a different sequence, that would be due to missing segments, but only at both ends, and also, if a segment is missing at the beginning the corresponding last segment would also be missing.

we realise that the ballads shared the universal features of oral compositions. The precise universal knowledge discerned in the *Vadakkan Pāṭṭukal* is their common structure, function, and sequence specific to the narrative order of all such stories. *Vadakkan Pāṭṭukal* are oral compositions based on stock expressions, a fixed order, usual figurative phrases, set descriptions of costumes, fights, routes, etc., and socially owned tools of composition, precluding a particular author.

Martial Practices

Kaḷaripayattu is the most famous traditional martial heritage of Kerala, meant for self-defence or protective counter-measure to guard one's health and wellbeing against natural or societal harms. It is based on a codified system that combines knowledge and skill (*Kaḷarividya*). Like any other martial traditional culture in Asia, *Kaḷaripayattu* has its physical and mental dimensions based on a foundational cosmology, physiology and anatomy. It also involved knowledge of healthcare, lifestyle disciplining, ritual, philosophy and meditation.

Kaḷarividya means knowledge acquired in a *Kaḷari*, a structure of 42 feet length and 21 feet width (*nalpathiradi sthanam*), a rectangular space dug out four to five feet below the ground level. *Kaḷarividya* comprises a wide array of knowledge, skills, beliefs, rituals, myths and visions. It would include the practices related to aspects of knowledge such as pedagogy, martial art, self-defence, mind, healthcare, medicine, anatomy, metallurgy, astrology, meditation, sporting and performing arts and ethico-spirituality. *Kaḷarimura* and *Kaḷaripayattu* are the terms related to the instructional aspect of a *Kaḷari* in northern Kerala. *Aṭimura*, *thaṭṭum thaṭayum*,

dear to me) 'tvadeeyapriyam' (what is dear to you) and 'aparapriyam' (dear to another). These are actually, 'priyavishayam prati vannitum bhramam' ('പ്രിയവിഷയം പ്രതി വന്നിടും ഭ്രമം') – puzzlement that prevails around each object of desire.

How to solve this puzzle? See the next verse: 'Priyamaparanteyathen priyam swakeeyapriyamaparapriyam' ('പ്രിയമപരന്തേയതൈൻ പ്രിയം സ്വകീയ- / പ്രിയമപരപ്രിയമിപ്രകാരമാകും'). This should be the *nayam* or strategy to be followed in this context. The convergence of Guru's notions of the 'self' on one side, and *priyam* or *sukham* on the other, can be seen in the twenty-fourth verse.

അവനിവന്നെന്നറിയുന്നതൊക്കെയൊർത്താ -
ലവനിയിലാഭിമമായൊരാത്തരുപം
അവനവനാത്തസുഖത്തിനാചരിക്കു-
ന്നവയപരന്നു സുഖത്തിനായ് വരേണം.

The metaphysical and ethical standpoints converge here and it is through that process that *jnana* manifests as *dharma*. But this manifestation does not restrict itself to the individual level. It has to be extended to a collective and social level also. That idea is expressed in four verses beginning from the forty-fourth verse,

പലമതസാരവുമേകമെന്നു പാരാ -
തുലകിലൊരാനയിലന്ധരെന്നപോലെ
പലവിധ യുക്തി പറഞ്ഞു പാമരന്മാ -
രലവതു കണ്ടലയാതമർന്നിടണം.

With regard to *jnana*, the interactions and relations between the three layers of 'I', 'you' and 'we' were identified earlier. Now with regard to *dharma* also, the three layers of 'oneself', the 'other self' and the 'collective'/'social' space have been pointed out. Manifestation of *jnana* as *dharma* through dialogues between the self and the other marks the core of Guru's philosophy.

Ayyankali's Militancy

Ayyankali (1863–1941) was the first reformer to protest against the caste-ridden society of Kerala without any recourse to the religious aura of a sage. He was exposed to the teachings of Ayya Vaikundar and Thycaud Ayyavu. A contemporary of Chattampi Swamikal and Narayana Guru, Ayyankali had witnessed their activities. Born on 28 August 1863 in Venganoor, Thiruvananthapuram, he was part of a Pulaya family which had, by comparison, better living conditions thanks to the five acres of land given by the landlord under whom they worked as slaves

(*adiyans*). Members of the Pulaya community generally worked as landless bonded labourers under their landlords (*janmis*). Ayyan was considered by them as their village leader (*Urpillai* or *Moothapillai*).

The Pulayar of his village and the surrounding areas joined Ayyan in forming a group to protest against the ill-treatment meted out to them as slaves and untouchables. Ayyan empowered them to challenge their oppressors, even physically, confronting the upper castes. In 1893, Ayyankali dared to dress like a landlord – with a high-caste headgear – riding in a bullock cart through a road forbidden to ‘polluting castes’. This is famous in history as Ayyankali’s *Villuvandi Samaram* (bullock cart rebellion).

Ayyankali set an inspiring example for his followers to enter market places and walk through public roads. Such moves often turned violent. Nevertheless, struggles such as the Chaliyar Riots helped the Pulayar win the right to use the public roads in Travancore



Statue of Ayyankali at Peeranki Maidanam near SN College, Kollam.

state, except those that led to temples. Ayyankali encouraged the people of his community to access education for being independent. A few Pulayars had gained access to schools set up by the colonial Missionary Society and London Missionary Society from around the mid-nineteenth century. Ayyankali wanted the government to extend its efforts in modernisation to the oppressed castes for their social welfare. Since the late-1890s, the government established several public schools for such communities. Soon, inspired by the Brahma Nishta Mattam of Ayyavu, Ayyankali founded the Sadhu Jana Paripalana Sangham (SJPS), a collective for the protection and welfare of the poor and untouchable castes.

Ayyankali’s attempt to enrol a Pulaya girl in a government school led to a violent backlash from upper castes, and eventually to the burning down of the school building in Ooruttambalam. Ayyankali called for a strike by agricultural labourers in the region. He asked his people to boycott the paddy fields owned by the upper castes until the government conceded to the demand for lifting all caste-based restrictions in education. Ayyankali represented the Pulayas and other enslaved castes in the Sree Moolam Popular Assembly, the legislative council of Travancore, in 1910.

He also fought for women's rights, and continued the Maru Marakkal Samaram for the women of the untouchable castes, following in the footsteps of Ayya Vaikundar (who had made the movement successful for the Nadar women). Ayyankali used to organise mass meetings and cultural events for the women of the oppressed castes. He mobilised them for political movements under Sadhu Jana Paripalana Sangham. His efforts were praised by Mahatma Gandhi during the latter's visit to Kerala in 1937 to celebrate the implementation of the Temple Entry Proclamation by the King of Travancore.

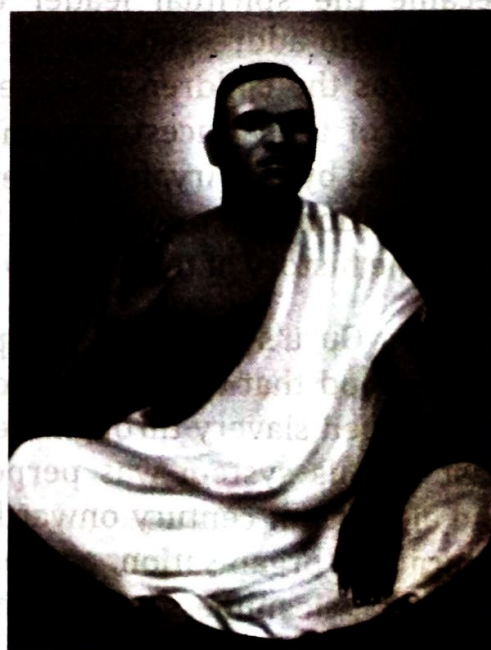
Ayyankali's contribution to knowledge was the politics of direct action in the form of physical resistance and riots by the oppressed, for their emancipation. He had understood the inevitability of the Pulaya labour in the agriculture economy, the material basis of the upper-caste domination. Withdrawal of this labour naturally forced the oppressor to concede. Another was the empowerment of the oppressed castes by spreading education, and through their mobilisation into a political collective through cultural festivals of singing and dancing, rather than through sentiments of religious devotion.



Who was Ayyankali? What was his contribution to Kerala Renaissance? Scan the QR code or visit the url <<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C8hhCfoTFtI>> to watch a video on his life and work.

Poykayil Yohannan

Another prominent leader of the enslaved castes was Poykayil Yohannan (1879–1939), born into an oppressed agricultural family bonded to a Christian landlord of Eraviperoor near Thiruvalla. A Marthomite Christian, and not liberated from the traditional caste bondage, Yohannan had his basic education and began his career as a field missionary assistant. An intelligent youngster, he developed insights into the miserable plight of his people despite their conversion to Christianity. Yohannan felt alienated from the missionary tasks entrusted to him. He could not find the gospels and the Christ as relevant to the life of his people, nor could he find the Christ worshipped by his people in the Bible.





Read more about Poykalyil Appachan here <<https://keralamuseum.org/article/songs-of-resistance-the-legacy-of-poykayil-appachan/>>, or by scanning the QR code.

Philosophy-In-Action: Social Movements and Knowledge Production

Social movements are distinctive because of their unique forms and ways of claim-making. They are not performed by individuals in isolation. They are collective campaigns. Such campaigns address those who are in power as well as the general public. They include public performances including marches, rallies, processions, demonstrations, occupations, blockades, public meetings, posters, ceremonial arches, cut-outs, oratory, delegations, statements in public media, petitions, pamphlets, and creation of associations and organisations. Such movements assert the ordinary people's right to participate in politics. In the context of Kerala, we have discussed campaigns and protests like the *Villuvandi Samaram* by Ayyankali, Malayali Memorial, Ezhava Memorial, Vaikom Satyagraha, formation of organisations like SNDP, Sadhu Jana Paripalana Sangham, PRDS, Yogakshema Sabha, Muslim Dharma Paripalana Yogam, Temple Entry Protests, inter-dining, etc.

Social movements generally question the existing knowledge base. People who are on the peripheries/margins assert their existence by questioning the 'common sense' which is accepted and established as knowledge. Thus, social movements often question what is considered to be scientific knowledge. They also problematise developmental paradigms. This is the way in which the struggles for survival contribute to the formation of new knowledge. Let us take a closer look at such interventions which played a significant role in the history of Kerala.

Philosophy as a Way of Life: Narayana Guru

Generally, philosophy students are introduced to the history of 'doing philosophy'. It was the Greeks who coined the term *philosophia* meaning 'love of wisdom'. Today we consider philosophy as an attempt to invent new concepts, systems and discourses. It does not presuppose a personal commitment towards such systems of thinking. For the sake of convenience, let us name this approach as 'academic' or 'technical' philosophy. It is done in a technical language meant for specialists.

But there are other ways of doing philosophy as well. In antiquity in the West as well as in some schools of thought in India, a personal commitment to the system of philosophy was the starting point of 'philosophising'. Philosophy is a way of life in such traditions, which enables one to think differently.

This does not imply that these two ways contradict each other. One can be termed abstract conceptualisation, whereas the other transforms the way one lives in the world. Let us define philosophy as thinking in terms of certain principles. This is applicable to both varieties mentioned above, as we can find certain principles behind the actions and practices of people.

Narayana Guru, as already discussed, was a philosopher who played a prominent role in transforming the lifeworld in Keralam during the initial stages of modernity. He wrote both prose and poetry. He was equally proficient in Sanskrit, Malayalam and Tamil. We can summarise the originality of Narayana Guru as a philosopher through two observations:

1. **Poetising instead of philosophising:** Though he extensively uses the word *arivu* (knowledge) in his works, his approach is not epistemological or rationalistic. His interventions in everyday life, perhaps, could be seen as rationalistic. His engagement with metaphysics is also not argumentative. He showed no interest in establishing any particular metaphysical standpoint including that of Advaita, Buddhism, or any other school. His interest was in realising such positions. To him, they are not philosophical truths, but poetic truths. Initially, he did write prose in the conventional academic style. But soon he turned to writing verses. Poetry was not a mere medium to him. This shift from writing prose to verse marks an important shift in his life as well. Poetry became a way of thinking for him. He was not expressing certain metaphysical standpoints through verse. If we isolate certain stanzas from his writings and interpret them by drawing on certain metaphysical standpoints, they may appear as philosophical statements. But if we take those works as a whole, that is not the case. They are unique in the way in which the predicament of *arivu* is expressed. His originality in philosophising consisted in the poetic integration and improvisations of many traditions of thought in India. For him, poetry was an experimental lab where new recipes were indulged in fearlessly without strict adherence to any particular culinary style. Narayana Guru integrated insights from various sources and traditions. Thus, we can consider him as a philosopher because of his way of life; not merely because of the works he authored. He was a philosopher because of his existential commitment. He

never stopped practising it. He did not live tradition (be it social, cultural or religious), but lived a philosophical life. His philosophical life immensely transformed the social, cultural and religious lives around him, and a new ethics came into being. *That is why he is considered as the founder of Kerala modernity.* In everyday situations, his interventions affected a transformation of sensibility in others around him. It will be futile if we try to capture that transformation by interpreting it as an 'application' of any one metaphysical theory, be it Advaita, Saivism or Buddhism. There was a creative aspect both in his expressions and acts. To think was to create for him. The medium for expression was not merely language, but his body, being and life as a whole. Ways of being, ways of acting and ways of knowing were linked closely. Guru showed an intensity and integrity in thinking and living. His attempt was not to essentialise knowledge, but to bring that intensity to knowledge. Knowledge or *arivu* was a starting point, not the final goal to him.

2. **Translation instead of interpretation:** As seen above, Guru's attempt was not to interpret and establish metaphysical standpoints. He tried to translate and realise certain poetic truths in life. That is why poetry became a way of thinking to him. This meant that words will have an impact on life. Guru's works consist of a profound variety of genres including *keerthanas*, prayers and hymns. Such discourses do not intend to transmit information, but to produce a certain psychic effect in the reader or listener (as discussed by Pierre Hadot, a French philosopher, in his *The Veil of Isis: An Essay on the History of the Idea of Nature*, pages 19–20). It aims to form and transform new selves rather than inform knowledge. Learning in such a context is not limited to intelligence, but to imagination, sensibility and will, as well. The name of one of his works is *Athmopadesa Satakam*, i.e., One Hundred Verses in Self-Counselling. It is not meant for teaching any particular system in philosophy, but to actualise such insights on the self. Let us look at three stanzas from this work:

പ്രിയമപരന്യതൈൻ പ്രിയം സ്വകീയ-
 പ്രിയമപരപ്രിയമിപ്രകാരമാകും
 നയമതിനാലെ നരന്നു നന്മ നൽകും
 ക്രിയയപരപ്രിയഹേതുവായ് വരേണം.

(That which is dear to another shall be dear to me; that which is dear to me shall be dear to others too. By such a tenet, any action that brings good to one man, should also be the cause of good to others.)

അവനിവന്നെന്നറിയുന്നതൊക്കെയൊർത്താ -
 ലവനിയിലാഭിമമായൊരാത്തരുപം
 അവനവനാത്തസുഖത്തിനാചരിക്കു-
 നവയപരന്നു സുഖത്തിനായ് വരേണം.

(Whatever is known as 'that' or 'this' man, when one thinks of it, are but forms of the primeval Self in the world. Whatever one does for one's own happiness, should also bring happiness to the other.)

ഒരുവനു നല്ലതുമന്യനല്ലലും ചേർ -
 ഞാരു തൊഴിലാത്തവിരോധി,യൊർത്തിടേണം.
 പരന്നു പരം പരിതാപമേകിടുന്നോ -
 രെരിനരകാബ്ധിയിൽ വീണെരിഞ്ഞിടുന്നു.

(Any action that brings good to one but sorrow to the other, one must realise, is hostile to the true self. Those who thus bring great pain to the other, shall fall and burn in the raging sea of hell-fire.)

The Problem of 'True Knowledge': Poykayil Appachan

Does history embody true knowledge of the past? Sanal Mohan has shown how Dalit movements in Kerala engaged with this problem of history. He has foregrounded the theorisation done by Poykayil Yohannan (later Kumara Guru Devan), founder of Pratyaksha Raksha Daiva Sabha (PRDS). The PRDS was founded in 1909 at Eraviperoor near Thiruvalla. It started as a movement in missionary churches but suddenly moved out of it. It was a powerful presence among the (Christian) Pulaya, Paraya and Kurava communities. Yohannan found that for Dalits, the lack of history was the root cause of their enslavement. He sang in one of his poems:

കാണുന്നില്ലാരക്ഷരവും
 എന്റെ വംശത്തെപ്പറ്റി
 കാണുന്നുണ്ടനേക
 വംശത്തിൻ ചരിത്രങ്ങൾ.

(I behold the histories of many races in Kerala, but none about my race.) Yohannan's attempt to imagine a history for those who lacked it, enabled them to step into history. This was not stepping into the past, but stepping into the modernity of Keralam.

The Coming of New Knowledge to Kerala: Translation, Modernisation and Social Reform

This chapter embodies the discussion of the entry of new knowledge fields, and the knowledge enshrined in them, as a result of the translation of knowledge from various cultures during the nineteenth and early-twentieth centuries.

Translation acquired the dimension of a movement of modernisation in the regional language. In fact, it was trans-creation of new knowledge, which introduced various new fields of knowledge and the method of producing scientific knowledge systems. Translators were not merely facilitators, but creative artists in their own right, partnering with original authors for bringing forth new meanings and perspectives.

How did translation become such an integral part of Malayalam literary culture?

Translation – generally understood as the process of converting the meaning from one language to another without losing the original message, feeling and tone of a text – is much more than that when you think about the cultural consequences. Translation involves the exchange and assimilation of ideas, values and knowledge from various cultures, languages and intellectual traditions. The process of translation has played a pivotal role in breaking linguistic and cultural barriers and bringing a region closer to the global literary works, ideas and knowledge. Enabling cross-cultural understanding and exchange, it facilitates learning across cultures in various subjects including science and technology.

In short, translation is a cultural process that plays a crucial role in transforming and reshaping a culture; it facilitates diffusion of a hitherto unfamiliar culture into a national another and subsequently into a regional culture. Generally, we distinguish the pre-existing culture as traditional and its transformed structure as modern. Sharing lived experiences, emotions and in essence the entire socio-political world brings forth the humanness of people beyond all barriers of identity and helps them re-orient themselves. This is the process of making a new way of life feasible. In the context of translations from European languages into Malayalam, this meant the transition from the traditional feudal order into the capitalist modern.

What is Modern?

It is relevant to define the meaning and implications of 'modern' here. When we say that a culture is transformed into another, a radical shift in the nature of the people's worldview and perception of life is implied. The spread of a new kind of knowledge called 'science' capable of questioning the traditional was central to this shift. Science and the scientific way of thinking had acquired a different meaning in the nineteenth century

The origin of translation stretches back to antiquity, driven by the fundamental need for communication between diverse linguistic groups. Early evidence, like the Sumerian *Epic of Gilgamesh* translations and the multilingual Rosetta Stone (c. 196 BCE), highlights its ancient roots. Driven by trade, diplomacy, and the spread of knowledge, these initial efforts laid the groundwork for the complex field of translation, bridging cultural and linguistic divides across millennia.

Europe with the renaming of Isaac Newton's seventeenth-century thesis *Principia Mathematica*, originally known as *The Mathematic Principles of Natural Philosophy*.

Isaac Newton's theories had rattled the world of scholars and accounted for the emergence of the Age of Enlightenment, also known as the Age of Scientific Reason, which lasted roughly from 1685 to 1815. This intellectual shift made Newton the father of science, and his science, i.e., Newtonian Physics, the foundation of modern knowledge. The meaning of 'modern' has to be thus, explained against the above context of the history of science. Likewise, the implications must be interpreted against the context of the spread of science the world over.

Modernisation through Translation

Translation of secular works in foreign languages, initially from English and subsequently from other European languages enabled the literate in India to acquaint themselves with the ideas, outlooks and knowledge of the modern world. English writings got translated mostly into Bengali during the late eighteenth century as Calcutta was the capital of British India from 1772–1911 and there was a lot of emphasis on education in English and the vernacular. Kerala was also equally developing intellectually and culturally; many Bengali writings of the period were being translated into Malayalam since 1772. Many English educated people of Kerala had been employed in Calcutta and they were instrumental in transporting the ideas of the modern Western world to Kerala. Great Russian and Soviet writers like Anton Chekov, Dostoevsky, Maxim Gorky, Tolstoy, Sholokhov and their writings were known to the literati of Kerala through these people

working in Calcutta. Some of them had also begun translations of the English versions of certain works into Malayalam.

The translation of poems, stories and novels from the modern world began in the 1890s and was later followed by the translation of other literary works. Translation of knowledge texts, mainly from history and philosophy, came next. All this modernised the readership as well as the Malayalam language, leading to the emergence of a chaste prose. These translations began to introduce realism into Malayalam short stories and novels. Russian novelists like Dostoevsky and Tolstoy further enriched Malayalam literature through translations, significantly contributing to its growth.

The Making of a Malayali Identity through Translations

Metaphorically speaking, humans are translations themselves. Our daily lives are a constant series of translating thoughts and emotions, making translation an integral part of our existence. It is imperative to recognise that translation is not secondary to any activity; rather, it is a fundamental process that facilitates cross-cultural understanding.

Despite the advancements in science and technology, translation remains a vital component in various fields such as media, entertainment, trade and cross-cultural relations. Translations also play a vital role in the formation of literary cultures in Indian as well as world languages. As mentioned above, translations of works from European languages into Malayalam in the nineteenth century had led to the evolution of a new mentality and culture in Kerala, distinct from the traditional. One of the effects of this process of translation was the reproduction of modern knowledge infused with certain elements of Keralite or Malayali identity.

The evolution of Malayalam as a distinct language and the rich cultural heritage of Kerala serves as a testament to the profound impact of translation. Long before the advent of printing, revered books in Sanskrit were translated into Malayalam, with many of these ancient texts still preserved on palm leaves. Later, numerous seminal works were printed and published, further solidifying the role of translation in shaping Malayalam literature.

Translations from Sanskrit

Translation encompasses more than mere conversion of text from one language to another; it involves bridging cultural and linguistic divides, transforming ideas